violence committed during the Spanish conquest in 1519'. For Jawad Iqbal, 'this line of thinking also makes the mistake of confusing modern Spain with imperial Spain, as if the same state or ruling entity remained in power to this day'.[5] He argues that 'saying sorry is often a case of political expediency', so that it 'has no impact on current government policies' and is therefore an 'empty gesture'. It also 'can polarise people within the countries affected' so that 'it would be better to remember past wrongs in ways that bring people together rather than divide them'. Even so, he does accept that there is today 'the growing tendency for countries to acknowledge past crimes committed during colonisation'. This explains why in 1995 Queen Elizabeth II of England apologized for atrocities committed against the Maoris in New Zealand; in 2008, the Australian parliament formally apologized to indigenous Australians; in 2007, Tony Blair, the British PM, said sorry for the slave trade; in 2010, his successor, Gordon Brown apologized for sending 1,30,000 children to the former colonies. In a two-page letter in October 2020, Mexico's president also wrote to Pope Francis, asking for an apology for the Catholic Church's role in the oppression of indigenous people in the Spanish conquest 500 years ago.[6] Apologies and acts of atonement continue. Those wronged demand recognition of wrongdoing. They seek reparatory action. On 28 May 2021, Germany not only apologized to Namibia for its military's past violence which led to the killing of 80,000 Africans between 1904 and 1908, but also declared it to be 'genocidal', with a pledge of $1.3 billion in aid to Namibians.[7]

Nevertheless, Jawad says that 'such an approach makes no distinction between those in actual authority responsible for historical crimes and everyone else at the time', even as the clamour for an apology for colonial crimes continues to grow. One hundred years after the Amritsar Massacre, there was a brief statement in the House of Commons by Britain's Prime Minister Theresa May, who said: 'The tragedy of Jallianwala Bagh in 1919 is a shameful scar on British Indian history. As her majesty the Queen said before visiting Jallianwala Bagh in 1997, it is a distressing example of our past history with India.' She went on to add that 'we deeply regret what